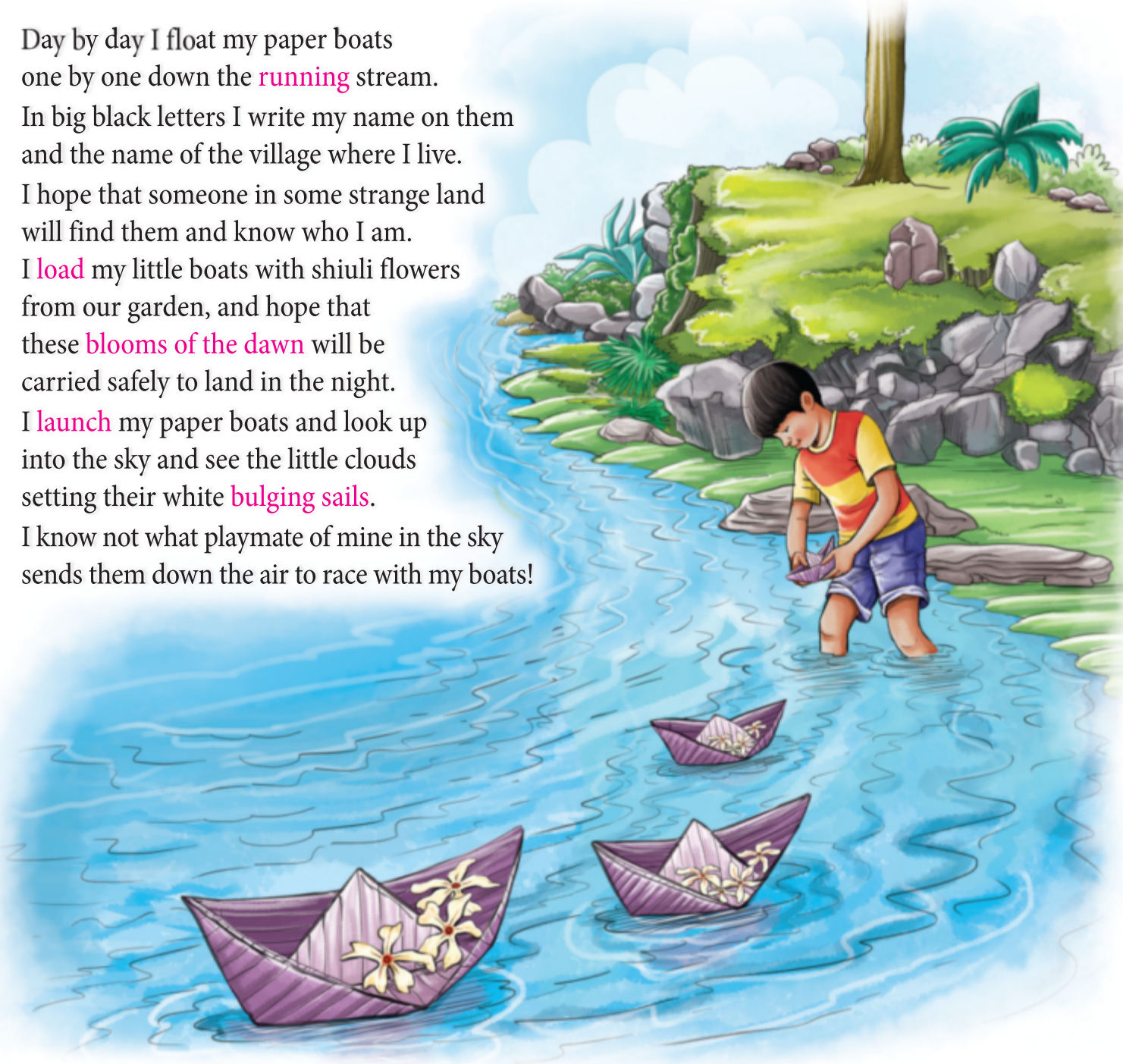


Paper Boats

Can a **flimsy** paper boat carry the weight of flowers and travel safely into a faraway land? Can it race with mighty clouds and remain **afloat**? Most importantly, can it carry the weight of dreams and hopes? Let us read the poem and find out.



Day by day I float my paper boats
one by one down the **running** stream.
In big black letters I write my name on them
and the name of the village where I live.
I hope that someone in some strange land
will find them and know who I am.
I **load** my little boats with shiuli flowers
from our garden, and hope that
these **blooms of the dawn** will be
carried safely to land in the night.
I **launch** my paper boats and look up
into the sky and see the little clouds
setting their white **bulging sails**.
I know not what playmate of mine in the sky
sends them down the air to race with my boats!



flimsy: not strong enough **afloat:** floating on water **running:** (here) flowing **load:** fill **blooms of the dawn:** flowers that open up early in the morning
launch: set the boat sailing **bulging sails:** sails puffed up because of the wind

When night comes I bury my face in my arms
and dream that my paper boats float on and on
under the midnight stars.

The fairies of sleep are sailing in them,
and the **lading** is their baskets full of dreams.

Rabindranath Tagore

Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941) was a famous writer, singer and painter. He composed the National Anthem of two countries (Bangladesh and India). His most notable work is his poetry collection, *Gitanjali*, for which he was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913, making him the first Indian to receive the award.



Make connections

Answer the following questions based on the poem.

In this section, we will:

- recognize relevant details to answer questions based on the poem.
- identify and interpret the central ideas of a poem. (C-2.1, C-2.2)

1. Complete the following sentences.
 - a. The person speaking in a poem is called the **persona**. The persona of the poem 'Paper Boats' is about _____ years old because _____.
 - b. The persona floated paper boats filled with _____, in the _____ stream.
 - c. The persona imagined that the clouds are _____ sent by an unknown _____ in the sky to race with his paper boats.

2. Read this line and answer the questions that follow.

In big black letters I write my name on them and the name of the village where I live.

- a. What does 'them' refer to?
 - b. Why did the persona write his name and the name of his village?
 - c. What does this tell you about the persona?
3. Did the persona float his boats often or did he rarely do this?
Which words in the poem give us the answer to this question?
 4. At night, what dreams did the persona have about his boat?



lading: the things they are carrying

Appreciation



Rhythm

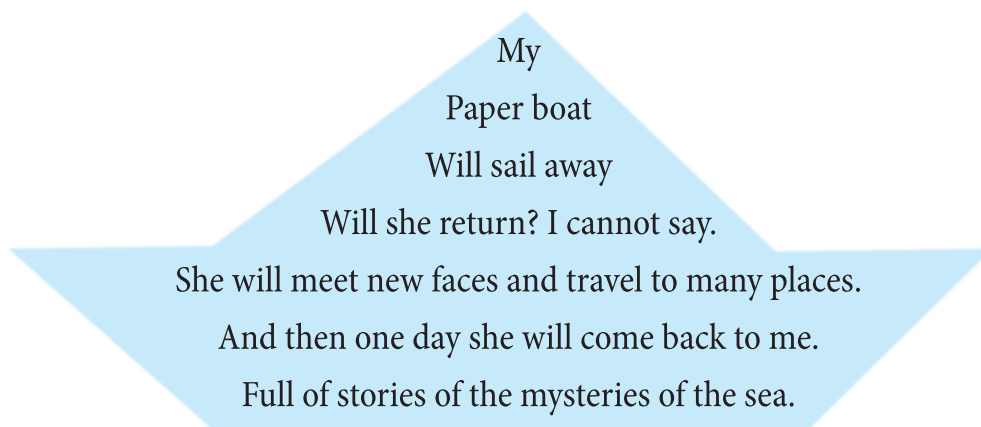
When we read Tagore's poem 'Paper Boats', we see that the lines do not rhyme. All poems need not have a rhyme. Most poems have a rhythm or a beat like that of a song.

Ask your teacher to read the poem aloud. Now, in groups of five or six, compose a tune for the poem and share it with the class.

Concrete poems

A **concrete poem** is one that takes the shape of what it writes about.

Example:



Use your imagination and write a concrete poem about a paper boat of your own.

The lines don't have to rhyme. They only have to change in length to make the shape of a paper boat. Here are some points you can think about:

1. Where would you like your boat to sail to?
2. Who are the people your boat would meet?
3. What cargo would you like the boat to carry back for you?



Did you know?

The art of paper folding is called **origami**. It usually involves folding a square paper in different ways to create two-dimensional and three-dimensional objects.



In this section, we will:

- learn to compose a rhythm or a beat for a poem.
- learn to create a concrete poem. (C-3.2, C-3.3)